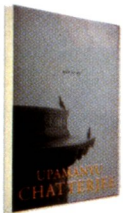


Chronicle of DEATHS FORETOLD

Every ending is tragic in the bleak world of Upamanyu Chatterjee's new novel

By Brinda Bose



WAY TO GO
by UPAMANYU
CHATTERJEE
Hamish Hamilton
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Is the title of Upamanyu Chatterjee's latest novel, *Way to Go*, a pun? Does it, with Chatterjee's trademark gloweringly dark humour, commend a path to dusty death that can be cheered lustily along? The absence of an exclamation point at the end of the phrase is, of course, a teaser. Here is a novel about death—the anticipation of it, the discovery of it, the shock and awe of it, the mystery and (dis)appearance of it—that could perhaps be meant to ease our understanding of it with a wicked, doomed peal of laughter. That the laugh might die along your throat as it rises is presumably intentional, too.

Way to Go is a sequel to Chatterjee's 1993 novel *The Last Burden*, which also featured a prolonged dying at the centre of it. Shyamanand, now 85 and partially-paralysed, is a widower whose long-suffering wife Urmila's death was the one he and his sons Burfi and Jamun had wrestled with in the earlier work of fiction. Clearly, Chatterjee's preoccupation with ways of dying has permeated multiple levels of thinking and being in his fictional protagonists almost two decades later, so much so that *Way to Go* is not merely a contemplation of myriad "ways to go", but is a chronicle of many deaths foretold, witnessed, heralded or surprised—but hardly ever mourned.

Mostly, its formidable, ferocious bleakness is only relieved by Chatterjee's famed barking satire, a humour so dark and relentless that it merely contributes to the general malaise of despair. At odd, exquisitely precious moments,

What is memorable about the book is that the primrose path is paved with a continually chiselled linguistic power that is at once elegant and knife-edge brittle.



UPAMANYU CHATTERJEE

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however, *Way to Go*'s intractably morose vision is uplifted by flashes of tenderness, so fleeting that you might miss them if you blink: between old father Shyamanand and ageing son Jamun, between an unacknowledged "daughter" Mithi and her "Jamun Uncle" whom she uncannily resembles, between brothers Burfi and Jamun, distanced and desolate as they shore up against the ruins of their tattered inheritances. While there can be hardly any denying that the universe that Shyamanand and his now-deceased wife Urmila had bleakly created for their unremarkable family with every rupee of their life's worth is a sullen metaphor for a